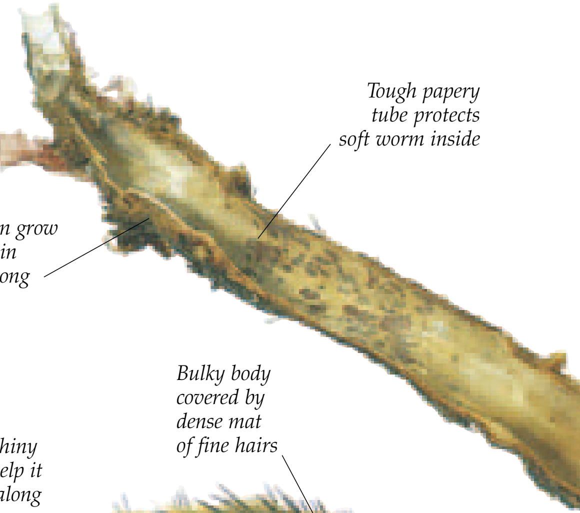
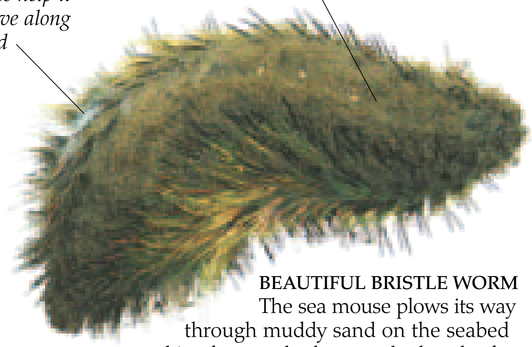
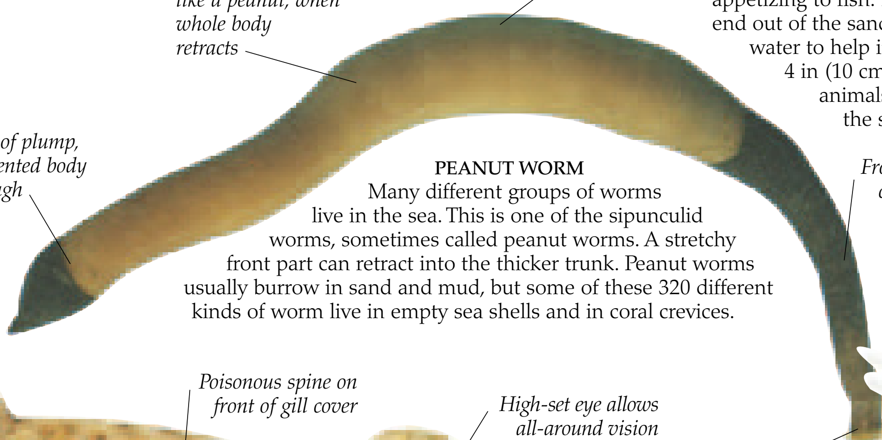
Sandy and muddy

IN SHALLOW COASTAL WATERS, from the lowest part of the shore to the edge of the continental shelf, sand and mud are washed from the land, creating vast stretches of seafloor which look like underwater deserts. Finer-grained mud settles in places where the water is calmer. Without rocks, there are no abundant growths of seaweeds, so animals that venture onto the surface are exposed to predators. Many of the creatures avoid them by hiding in the soft seabed. Some worms hide inside their own tubes, but they can feed by spreading out a fan of tentacles or by drawing water containing food particles into their tubes. Other worms, such as the sea mouse, move around in search of food. Flat fish, like the flounder, are commonly found on the sandy seabed, looking for any readily available food, such as peacock worms. All the animals shown here live in the coastal waters of the Atlantic Ocean.

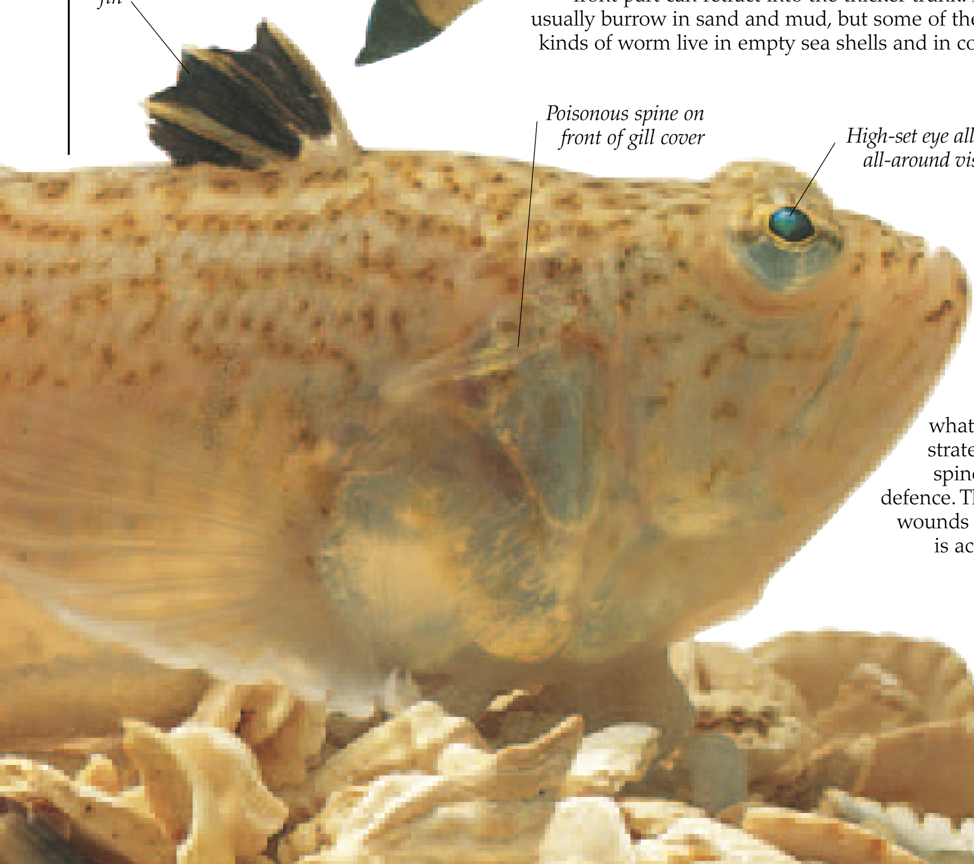




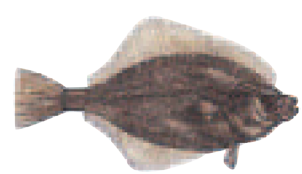
BEAUTIFUL BRISTLE WORM
The sea mouse plows its way through muddy sand on the seabed and is often washed up on the beach after storms. The shiny, rainbow-colored spines help propel it along and may make this chunky worm less appetizing to fish. The sea mouse usually keeps its rear end out of the sand to bring in a stream of fresh sea water to help it breathe. Sea mice grow to 4 in (10 cm) long and eat any dead animals they may find in the sand.



PEANUT WORM
Many different groups of worms live in the sea. This is one of the sipunculid worms, sometimes called peanut worms. A stretchy front part can retract into the thicker trunk. Peanut worms usually burrow in sand and mud, but some of these 320 different kinds of worm live in empty sea shells and in coral crevices.



WARY WEEVER
When a weever fish is buried in sand, its eyes on top of its head help it see what is going on. The weever's strategically placed poisonous spines provide it with extra defence. The spines can inflict nasty wounds on humans, if a weever is accidentally trodden on in shallow water or caught in fishermen's nets.



FLAT FISH
Flounders cruise along the seabed looking for food. They can nibble the tops off peacock worms, if they are quick enough to catch them.